NORTH BERWICK SELECT BOARD MINUTES
JUNE 2, 2026

Present: Chairperson Michael Johnson Jr., Vice Chairperson Jonathan Hall, Selectperson Wendy Cowan, Selectperson Michael Johnson Sr., Selectperson Rebecca Reed

Also Present: Dwayne Morin, Mark Reed, Superintendent Audra Beauvais, Assistant Superintendent Susan Austin

1. PLEDGE OF ALLEGIANCE

2. REVIEW AND APPROVE MINUTES OF MAY 19, 2026

Dwayne stated he had made some formatting changes. Selectperson Cowan motioned to approve the minutes as amended for May 19th, 2026. Selectperson Johnson, Sr. seconded the motion. VOTE: 5-0.

3. PUBLIC INPUT

There was no public input.

4. UNFINISHED BUSINESS:

A. FY26 COMMITMENT: Update- Abatements and Supplementals

Dwayne updated the Board on the Pratt and Whitney account saying that there is a walkthrough of the building scheduled for this Friday, June 5th, with our assessor and the consultant that was hired to review the project. He expects that a report will be submitted sometime next week and then we can move forward with scheduling an abatement hearing.

B. REVALUATION: Update

Dwayne reported that KRT continues to move forward in the data collection stage of the revaluation with no real issues.

C. COMMUNITY RESILIENCE: New Application Submission

After the last submission, Dwayne took the comments to heart and expanded the application from 4 pages to 72 pages to make it an extremely comprehensive application for the 3 projects of installing EV charging stations, heat pump and hot water heaters at Public Works and Transfer Station, and vulnerable population notifications. He wanted to update the Board before submitting it and will submit it tomorrow, with the expected notification of approval or denial in October.

D. ELECTRICITY CONTRACT: Update on Rates

Dwayne updated the Board that the pricing as discussed at the last meeting was not actually going to be the price due to one of the providers charging DASI (Day-Ahead Ancillary Services) fees in the contract. Upon further investigation, Dwayne stated he did not feel comfortable going under contract with them. He reached out to a previous consultant that we had worked with before, Denise Luke, and she was able to offer a $0.1299 rate, plus on the day of signature's DASI rate, locked in for 36 months through Smartest Energy. If the DASI rate drops, credit will be given to our account. He also let the Board know that Smartest Energy, out of Syracuse, NY, is a more natural based energy company that uses solar and wind energy.

Selectperson Hall motioned that Dwayne enter a three-year electrical contract with Smartest Energy. Selectperson Cowan seconded the motion. VOTE: 5-0.

Selectperson Hall amended the previous motion that Dwayne enter an electrical contract at his discretion. Selectperson Cowan seconded the motion. VOTE: 5-0.

E. FIRE/RESCUE STATION: Update

The bid packets for contractors have been sent out, and Dwayne has a meeting with the architects next week. Proposals for soil testing and surveying have come back and are significantly lower than budgeted for, which is great news. Dwayne stated he reached out to Senator Collins' office because, other than the letter stated we received the grant, we have not had any other communication or direction for grant funds to be disbursed. The response he received is that the State is behind and nobody has received any of their funding. We may need to update the schedule; however, we are continuing forward in the process with most of the summer and fall being dedicated to this project.

F. MAPLE STREET FOREST: Footbridge Update

Dwayne stated that Mr. Peter Derby went out and measured what would be needed for the footbridge project for the trails off Maple Street. He came back stating that approximately 400 feet, both repaired footbridges and new, would be needed for this project. A total of 7 sections equating to 9 bridges would be proposed. The cost is $375.00 to build 12 feet sections and would need to be constructed in the forest as we do not have the equipment to build and bring in. Dwayne is going to try to apply for a grant to see if we can get funding and the plan would be to purchase materials with in-house construction. He states this could be a huge improvement to our trail system and we could have a group of volunteers help clean up the trails as well.

Reminders: Next Select Board's Meeting – June 19, 2026 – 6:30 P.M.-Room 212

5. NEW BUSINESS:

A. MSAD60 BUDGET: Meeting with Superintendent Beauvais

Superintendent of Schools for MSAD60, Audra Beauvais, started the meeting with a presentation of the school budget that is going to be voted on next week. Susan Austin, Assistant Superintendent of Schools, was also present as part of the discussion and to assist by fielding questions from the Board. Audra started by thanking the Board for their time now and being present at the Public Hearing held on May 7. She also wanted to note that a reporter for the Portland Press Herald is doing articles on schools in York County and Noble was featured in an appropriate light. Another note she stated before she presented the budget was the numbers were slightly off in the packet because the public voted to add $300,000.00 back into the Transportation line at the hearing.

Audra began by telling the Board that they worked hard to keep the budget below an 8% increase, however the addition of $300,000.00 to their final draft of the budget made that difficult and they ended up with an 8.61% increase. Originally, the numbers came in at 22% so they worked hard to bring that down because the understanding is there that things are tight for everyone currently. She explained that they start with a zero-based budget to keep it logical and fiscally responsible.

Audra let the Board know that they had 5 major goals in the creation of this budget which were absorbing the cost of the second year of Pre-K implementation, piloting (with reimbursement) providing services for 3 and 4 year olds that are ordered by their doctor to receive speech and OT services, continued growth of the MTSS (Multi-Tiered Support System) services for behaviors currently seen in the schools, the five year facilities plan, and curriculum development, which was in its scheduled year for review/updating.

Selectperson Cowan asked if the pre-K was currently operating on a lottery system and what the future of that system looks like. Audra and Susan answered that currently it operates that way however they hope to have it integrated by 2028 as a regular registration process. Selectperson Cowan also asked if the curriculum programs they pilot have assessments built in to gauge the success of the curricula as it is being piloted live, to which they answered that it does and they are constantly reviewing it.

Selectperson Hall asked about how the $300,000.00 addition to the transportation line is planned to be spent. Audra and Susan understood public wanted it to go to salaries, however the salaries are under contract with the drivers' union and are comparable to surrounding communities. They are exploring options for this added revenue such as training and CDL licensing.

Selectperson Cowan asked if there was anything North Berwick specific that the Board should know about. Audra responded that the North Berwick Elementary School building needs work done so they are focusing on that. Currently, the ADA is not up to Code but is not in violation yet. The PTO is also working on getting grants to upgrade playground equipment. They added a behavioral interventionalist position to focus on support and heightening skills for the elementary students.

After some discussion of other buildings in the district, Selectperson Cowan asked about the Mary Hurd Academy and how enrollment is there. Audra replied that currently there are 18 students, which is small but a great option for students to mitigate out of district placements. Out of district placements average about $120,000.00 per student per year so this is a savings to the district. Other programs that run out of the Mary Hurd Academy include transitions/life skills program, community clothing closet, the MSAD 60 Backpack Program (which averages 125 backpacks going out per week), and the North Berwick Food Pantry so the building is getting a lot of use outside of just schooling. Selectperson Reed asked if there were any current tuition students to which Audra and Susan answered there are 2, one from Wells and one from New Hampshire. Selectperson Hall asked if this program was going to open to 7th graders and Susan answered that it cannot due to a state requirement regarding grade spanning.

Dwayne addressed the budget book stating there were several people who didn't have it readily available before the public hearing. He also stated he couldn't find it on the website today to prepare it for tonight's meeting, which is why he emailed a few times. Audra and Susan said they used Edison Press and had it out to them and ready to be mailed May 1st. Extra copies were also available at the hearing, and the website has had it posted since it was completed. They also said they held 3 public sessions at libraries during the day for folks who couldn't come to the hearing. The communications position at the superintendent's office has been cut so the remaining staff are going to absorb the duties as best as they can. Audra said they are always working to improve.

Dwayne asked about the State's upcoming changes to the EPS formula, stating he believes that it will most likely negatively impact the district after a 3 year hold harmless period. Susan answered they believe that there might be a slight increase but will continue to monitor it. Audra stated the district is down 85 students spread over K-12, which made it difficult to focus in one specific grade area for cuts this year. She did state that more money is coming in for the special needs population. Dwayne commented that the population nationally is decreasing due to people not having kids or as many kids as in the past. Another factor that could affect that number are options like homeschooling.

Chairperson Johnson, Jr. asked if the district could bill insurances for the speech/OT services that are being recommended by doctors to try and get a revenue return. Susan responded that it is onerous and difficult. The district used to use Maine State Billing and then it became scrutinized. Options are out there that have been discussed by district staff and will continue to be part of discussions going forward.

B. ZONING ORDINANCE AMENDMENTS: Shooting Ranges and Data Centers

Dwayne said he has done a lot of research on these two topics due to the concerns brought up by a resident and the Select Board. He started the discussion with shooting ranges which has the state definition of sport shooting range and updated drafted Land Use table. He stated once this is enacted the current range would be a non-conforming use and that would restrict any future expansion. The Board did not want to penalize the responsible gun range owners from having an ability to expand indoor ranges on their property so they asked Dwayne if he could draft up some language that could allow them to expand on their current property but restrict additional ranges or expansion through purchase of new land.

Selectperson Cowan motioned to not allow gun ranges in any zone and continue working the language of the Ordinance draft to continue the conversation. Selectperson Hall seconded the motion. VOTE: 5-0.

Dwayne then moved the conversation to data centers. It was mentioned earlier in the meeting that Sanford put a 6-month moratorium on data centers at the last Council meeting. He included an article he found recently regarding language, definitions, and zoning around data centers that he reviewed. He would like to make the definition language as comprehensive as possible to avoid any potential future liability trouble. In his research, he found a variety of definitions from around the country including New Albany, OH, Harrisonburg, VA, Limerick Township, PA, Loudoun County, VA, Chandler, AZ, Fairfax County, VA, and the State of Maine. Selectperson Cowan asked if he had a favorite and Dwayne responded that he thought both Harrisonburg and New Albany's due to their thorough and comprehensive approach at defining data centers. The Board discussed the process of instituting a moratorium; however they decided this is a more pressing issue and are going to go through the process of getting it on the November ballot. Dwayne stated the deadline to go to November ballot is by September 1st and the Board expressed interest. Dwayne is going to draft up a definition for the next meeting to move the process forward.

C. HRA: Change Providers from Flores HR to Consumer Health Solutions

Dwayne said that we are looking to change our HRA from Flores to Consumer Health Solutions from Massachusetts, which consists of a lot of the same people who used to work for the previous HRA company we used, General Dynamics. There have been major concerns with Flores including delays in reimbursement to employees, a difficult to use portal, inaccessibility of basic customer service, and perceived unwillingness to reimburse the Town for an accidental extra payment. Dwayne also said that many Maine municipalities that use MMA for HRAs are moving away from Flores and toward Consumer Health Solutions.

Selectperson Hall asked if we were breaking contract and Dwayne responded that we never signed a contract with these folks when the transition happened. He also stated there is a monthly fee of $5.50/employee that Flores charges and Consumer Health Solutions only charge a monthly fee of $4.00/employee. As of 5pm this evening, the Town was done with Flores. Consumer Health Solutions needs 30 days to make the transition happen.

Selectperson Hall motioned to allow Dwayne to enter a contract with Consumer Health Solutions. Selectperson Johnson, Sr. seconded the motion. VOTE: 5-0.

6. OTHER BUSINESS

A. Security Computer

Dwayne alerted the Board that a few weeks ago the security computer for the Town Hall died and he had to get it replaced immediately. He was impressed with Dell because they were able to get a new computer, installed and running, the day after he called. He wanted to let the Board know this means we will carry a negative balance into the next year, as it cost $2,800.00 to replace, buy software, and install.

B. Police: Detective Cruiser Update

Dwayne stated that after months of searching, they found a detective cruiser in Oklahoma. It was at the higher end of the budget; however, it is a 2025 Dodge Charger with less than 30,000 miles on it in mint condition. We average about 20,000 miles a year on the detective cruiser, so this was a great investment for years to come. A deposit was put on the vehicle today and one of the police officers will be driving it back to Maine, as he had a paintball tournament near where the cruiser was located.

7. REVIEW AND APPROVE WARRANTS AND CORRESPONDENCE:

Warrant:	May 26, 2026	- $ 18,484.47
Warrant:	June 2, 2026	- $ 121,424.41

Selectperson Hall motioned to accept the warrant for May 26, 2026, in the amount of $18,484.47 and the warrant for June 2, 2026, in the amount of $121,424.41. Selectperson Reed seconded the motion. VOTE: 5-0.

8. ADJOURNMENT:

Selectperson Cowan motioned to adjourn at 8:13 p.m. Selectperson Reed seconded the motion. VOTE: 5-0.

Respectively Submitted,

Bonnie Michaud, Stenographer
Original to Town Clerk

Chairperson: Michael Johnson, Jr.

Selectperson: Jonathan Hall

Selectperson: Michael Johnson, Sr.

Selectperson: Wendy Cowan

Selectperson: Rebecca Reed